



TENSION IN THE AIR
(From left) PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti; BJP president J.P. Nadda with J&K state unit chief Ravinder Raina at a party event in Jammu

Photographs by ANI

had been part of an alliance government with the PDP. But all is not well in the party. Facing a revolt from the old guard, it was forced to withdraw the first candidates' list within hours on August 26. A revised list saw only 15 candidates for the first phase (two more lists have come out since, with 29 candidates), but top leaders like former deputy CM Nirmal Singh, ex-minister Sat Sharma and state party chief Ravinder Raina don't find a place. In the Valley too, BJP leaders are unhappy. Party spokesperson Altaf Thakur apparently had his nomination papers ready for Tral, but was ignored. The seat is one of eight in Kashmir, which the BJP is not even contesting.

THE PDP IS IN DISARRAY AFTER THE DISASTROUS LOK SABHA OUTING, PERHAPS WHY MEHBOOBA SAID SHE WILL SUPPORT AN NC-CONGRESS GOVT

The two mountainous districts of Rajouri and Poonch (Pirpanjal), which have seen renewed militancy since 2021, will be a focus area for all the parties. Following the delimitation exercise, the districts have eight seats between them, which fact makes the region "electorally significant" for government formation. With a 50 per cent Gujjar-Pahari population, the region was with the NC till 2014 when it gave Mehbooba Mufti's PDP three seats, two to the BJP and one each to the NC and the Congress.

This time, the BJP is banking on the votes of the Pahari-speaking ethnic groups, the upper-caste Syed Muslims and Gadda Brahmins who were granted Scheduled Tribe (ST) status recently, bringing them on par with the tribal Gujjar and Bakerwal communities. The move has prompted several prominent politicians from the Pahari community to join the saffron party, boosting its confidence. Significantly, four of the nine seats reserved for the ST community fall in Rajouri, Thanamandi, Budhal, Surankote and Mendhar in Poonch.

As for the PDP, it has been in tumult for some time now after it got a lead in only five assembly segments in the Lok Sabha election. The return of some of its leaders, such as former ministers Abdul Haq Khan and Basharat Bukhari, will be a boost, but there's still a big question mark over its winnability quotient, perhaps why party chief Mehbooba Mufti has already announced that they would back an NC-Congress government if the numbers were not in their favour.

Barring the BJP, the key issue for every party this election is the restoration of Article 370 and statehood. Already, issues such as the 2022 paper leak scam in government job recruitments, land rights for locals and high power bills have spurred protests, more prominently in Jammu. If some of these issues catch fire during the campaign, it could dent the saffron party's chances.

Omar is confident his party will form the government. The NC has come up with 12 guarantees in its manifesto focused on 'dignity, identity and development'. The former CM was initially not planning to contest (he had vowed to never be a member of a downgraded UT assembly), but has since had a "rethink" and will now be the NC candidate from Ganderbal, a family bastion in central Kashmir which has elected three generations of Abdullahs.

Meanwhile, there is a new contender, the AIP, which is fielding candidates across Kashmir. Omar had lost to AIP's Engineer Rashid—incarcerated in Tihar jail since 2019 on alleged terror funding charges—in Baramulla in May. The party had campaigned on the '*Tihar ka badla vote se*' slogan in the general election. Building on the momentum, Rasheed's brother has quit his government job and is contesting, while the MP has also filed for bail. "If he comes out and campaigns, we'll see what happens," says an NC leader. "Rasheed's emotional campaign was unique, but I don't think it will resonate in the assembly poll." One party that could be rooting for such an outcome would be the BJP, as the split in votes would be to its benefit. ■